

THE WAY

Teaching & Practice Baseline

What the Way presently teaches, practices, permits, and leaves open

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Founding synthesis - not a creed of compulsory assent

Truth precedes the institution. Conscience is never surrendered. Authority is entrusted and limited.

1. Purpose and use

This baseline is the public operational teaching standard for the founding period. It does not demand assent to every proposition as a condition of human dignity, attendance, friendship, or charitable assistance. It tells Teachers, Ministers, Houses of Prayer, and Companions which claims may be taught directly, which require qualification, and which must remain open.

Rule: Confidence may never outrun evidence, and practice may never outrun rights.

2. Confidence grammar

Status	Public teaching rule
Established	May be taught directly while grounds and revisability remain visible.
Well-Supported	Teach as the best current conclusion with significant limitations acknowledged.
Provisional	Teach as a working conclusion or experimental practice under review.
Permitted Interpretation	May be held, explored, or used devotionally; no conformity required.
Open Question	Present competing views fairly; the Assembly has no settled conclusion.
Rejected as Harmful or Unsupported	May be studied historically, but may not be used to govern, coerce, or harm participants; reasons must be recorded.

3. Foundational teaching baseline

ID	Domain	Status	Current baseline
TB-001	Ultimate reality	Established	Religions make materially different claims about God/ultimate reality; the Way does not erase those differences.
TB-002	God-language	Provisional	Companions and Houses may pray using ordinary God-language and other honest devotional language; no comprehensive metaphysics of God is yet fixed.
TB-003	Revelation method	Established	A revelation claim is testimony requiring evaluation; intensity, sincerity, office, charisma, prediction, or altered state does not itself establish divine origin.
TB-004	Revelation authority	Established	No claimed revelation overrides consent, safeguarding, law, financial

ID	Domain	Status	Current baseline
			controls, governing documents, or another adult's conscience.
TB-005	Jesus - history	Established	Jesus was a first-century Jewish figure whose movement continued after his crucifixion under Pontius Pilate.
TB-006	Jesus - metaphysics	Open Question	Incarnation, ontological divine sonship, Trinity, atonement mechanisms, miracle causation, and resurrection metaphysics are not presently Way doctrine.
TB-007	Muhammad - history	Established	Muhammad was a seventh-century Arabian religious and political leader; the Qur'an is the earliest principal textual witness to his proclamation.
TB-008	Muhammad - revelation/finality	Open Question	Divine authorship of the Qur'an and finality of prophethood are studied seriously but are not present Assembly doctrine.
TB-009	Buddha - history/teaching	Established	A historical Gautama stands behind Buddhism; early teaching strongly centers suffering, causation, cessation, disciplined practice, impermanence, and non-self.
TB-010	Buddha - metaphysics	Open Question	Rebirth, karma across lives, nirvana's metaphysical nature, and final implications of non-self remain open.
TB-011	Scripture/canon	Established	The Assembly maintains a Library of Witnesses rather than a closed canon.
TB-012	Human dignity	Established	Human dignity and conscience do not depend on membership, office, purity status, wealth, sex, belief certainty, or loyalty to the institution.
TB-013	Human fallibility	Established	Founders, ministers, councils, scholars, and Companions remain vulnerable to bias, self-deception, harmful desire, social influence, and error.
TB-014	Human transformation	Well-Supported	Attention, honesty, compassion, restraint, study, service, relationship,

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			accountability, and repair are defensible formation goals across multiple anthropological models.
TB-015	Soul / afterlife	Open Question	Immortal soul, bodily resurrection, rebirth, postmortem consciousness, annihilation, eternal separation, and universal reconciliation remain unresolved.

4. Ethical and pastoral baseline

Domain	Status	Operational baseline
Suffering	Established	Do not presume suffering is deserved, divinely inflicted, karmically deserved, or evidence of weak faith; prioritize care, lament, treatment, justice, and safety.
Theodicy	Open Question	No single explanation of suffering is adopted; proposed theodicies may not silence victims or excuse preventable harm.
Spiritual end	Provisional	Healing, liberation, reconciliation, awakening, wholeness, and right relationship may be used as comparative/working terms without declaring them metaphysically identical.
Exclusive salvation	Open Question	No current teaching that only Companions can be saved/liberated; no leader may claim knowledge of another person's ultimate destiny.
Intimate ethics	Established	Capacity, meaningful consent, non-exploitation, honesty, safeguarding, and responsibility to freely undertaken commitments/dependents are minimum standards.
Marriage theology	Open Question	Marriage sacramentality, same-sex blessing, divorce/remarriage, contraception, gender/sex metaphysics, plural marriage, celibacy, and related questions remain open.
Violence	Well-Supported	Strong presumption toward nonviolence, peacemaking, de-escalation, and protection of vulnerable persons; absolute pacifism

Domain	Status	Operational baseline
		remains open.
Religious violence	Established	No House, Minister, founder, Elder, or council may authorize vigilantism, holy war, coercive enforcement, or revelation-based exemption from law.

5. Practice baseline

5.1 Daily and personal

- Regular attention or stillness sufficient to cultivate honest awareness rather than dissociation or forced altered states.
- Prayer or contemplative practice according to conscience, using truthful language rather than compelled formulas.
- Study or reflection appropriate to season and capacity.
- Ethical self-examination focused on responsibility and repair rather than humiliation.
- Acts of care, generosity, service, or justice according to capacity.

5.2 Weekly and communal

- At least one recurring House or Assembly gathering rhythm for prayer, study, fellowship, service, or rest.
- Regular exposure to primary sources and competing interpretations rather than only leader summaries.
- Opportunities for questions, dissent, testimony, and silence without pressure to perform spirituality.
- A safeguarding and complaint route that does not depend on the local spiritual leader.

5.3 Prayer grammar

1. Stillness / attention
2. Remembrance
3. Praise and gratitude
4. Truth and examination
5. Petition and intercession
6. Listening and discernment
7. Dedication and sending

These movements are a grammar, not a mandatory script. Houses may develop language and music locally while preserving consent, theological honesty, accessibility, and the prohibition on binding personal revelations.

6. Gathering baseline

Gathering	Minimum purpose	Minimum integrity requirement
Prayer	Devotion, silence, gratitude, lament, intercession, remembrance.	No emotional manipulation, prophecy-as-command, forced disclosure, exhaustion, or restricted exit.
Study	Disciplined learning and inquiry.	Use primary sources/context, competing interpretations, and explicit uncertainty.
Service	Practical care.	No conversion, donation, loyalty, or silence requirement attached to aid.
Fellowship / Common Table	Hospitality, equality, relationship.	No status seating or exclusion from ordinary food because of belief, wealth, criticism, or departure.
Discernment	Test a question or proposed action.	State question, disclose conflicts, hear evidence/arguments, allow silence, record outcome and uncertainty.

7. Rites, sacred time, and fasting

- Rites may express commitment, memory, transition, healing, mourning, commissioning, reconciliation, and community; metaphysical efficacy must be labeled at the confidence actually warranted.
- Companion Commitment and Commissioning are presently usable forms. Child welcome, healing prayer, mourning/memorial, and reconciliation may be used provisionally with safeguards. Marriage/covenant blessing and ordination remain reserved.
- Develop rhythm before comprehensive calendar: daily practice, weekly gathering, periodic service/Common Table/study, and seasonal/annual remembrance may be piloted and reviewed.
- Inherited holy days may be observed or studied according to conscience but must remain identified with their source traditions unless separately adopted with clear theological reason.
- Fasting is optional/experimental until a fuller theology and safety standard exists. Health, disability, pregnancy, eating disorders, medication, strenuous labor, age, and other risks require full accommodation without spiritual penalty.

8. Ministry baseline

- Commissioning, not ordination, is the current authorization model.
- Every commission states scope, term/review, supervision, safeguarding requirements, complaint route, and financial authority if any.
- No commission creates ontological superiority, infallibility, immunity, sexual entitlement, automatic confidentiality privilege, or permanent office.
- Minister formation must include theology/religious literacy, source method, prayer leadership, pastoral boundaries, safeguarding, ethics/power, governance, conflict, referrals, practicum, and continuing review.
- A Minister may and should say "I do not know" where the baseline marks an Open Question.

9. Interreligious baseline

- Represent traditions accurately and preserve real disagreement.
- Dialogue does not require relativism; conviction does not justify coercion.
- Cooperate in common good without pretending doctrinal agreement.
- Becoming a Companion does not require denouncing ancestry, relatives, former communities, or every prior belief.
- Dual religious belonging remains open and must be handled honestly where another tradition treats initiation, covenant, creed, or law as exclusive.

10. What may not presently be taught as settled

- That all religions teach the same metaphysics.
- That one living leader has uniquely infallible access to ultimate reality.
- That a private revelation binds another adult without ordinary consent and governance.
- That Jesus' divinity/Trinity/atonement mechanics/resurrection metaphysics are established Way doctrine.
- That Muhammad's final prophethood or Qur'anic divine authorship are established Way doctrine.
- That Buddhist rebirth, nirvana metaphysics, or a final interpretation of non-self are established Way doctrine.
- That the Library of Witnesses is a canon.
- That a specific afterlife mechanism has been established.
- That one marriage/family model is a spiritual loyalty test.
- That ordination creates a metaphysically superior caste.

11. Teaching protocol for Houses and Ministers

1. Identify whether a material claim is historical, textual, phenomenological, philosophical, theological, ethical, symbolic, or institutional.
2. Identify the applicable confidence status where misunderstanding is reasonably likely.
3. Distinguish primary witness from later interpretation and institutional conclusion.
4. Represent significant competing interpretations fairly enough that a listener can understand the actual disagreement.
5. State known limitations and avoid manufactured certainty.
6. Identify practical and rights implications before a teaching is used to govern behavior.
7. Record material corrections publicly enough to prevent old errors from persisting by inertia.

12. Review cycle

- House-level questions and practice feedback are recorded continuously.
- The Teaching & Practice Baseline receives formal annual review during the founding period.

- Material change requires an evidence packet, competing interpretations, rights-impact review, recorded decision, effective date, and review date.
- No teaching becomes entrenched by repetition, popularity, founder preference, donor pressure, or liturgical habit.